

Belgium just won't give up

No one understands missed opportunities better than Belgium. Its vaunted golden generation, graced by stars such as Eden Hazard and Kevin De Bruyne, was expected to deliver the nation's first World Cup title. Instead, it could only go as far as the semifinals.

This time, the squad did not carry the same burden of expectation. The remnants of its golden generation, De Bruyne, Romelu Lukaku and Thibaut Courtois, were in the twilight of their careers, while a new crop of relatively lesser-known names did the heavy lifting.

Belgium began with tame draws against Egypt and Iran, and only secured its place in the Round of 32 after a 5-1 victory over New Zealand, the lowest-ranked team in the tournament.

The wheels appeared to be coming off in the first knockout round against Senegal, as Belgium trailed 2-0 until the 86th minute. But Youri Tielemans and Lukaku scored within three minutes of each other to force extra time. Tielemans then held his nerve to convert a penalty deep into the second half of extra time.

After its great escape, Belgium fired four past co-host USA in the Round of 16 before stretching Spain to the hilt in the quarterfinals. Charles De Ketelaere's header past Unai Simon was the only goal Spain conceded in the entire tournament.



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Cristiano Ronaldo takes his final bow, probably

Many believed Cristiano Ronaldo had bade farewell to the World Cup when he left the field in tears after Portugal's 1-0 defeat to Morocco in 2022. Yet, once again, Ronaldo persisted and defied the odds by appearing at the World Cup for a sixth time, at 41 years of age.

Despite calls to bench Ronaldo and claims that his presence hampered the Portuguese set-up, head coach Roberto Martinez insisted the team was better off with his experience. Portugal's 1-1 draw against DR Congo, in which Ronaldo failed to score, only intensified the pressure on Martinez.

But Ronaldo found his stride after scoring twice in Portugal's 5-0 win over Uzbekistan. He also made sure to remind the world, screaming, "I'm back, I'm back!" at the camera following him.

In the Round of 32, Ronaldo ended his World Cup knockout goal drought by converting a penalty in Portugal's 2-1 victory.

Yet, when Spain closed the door on Portugal in the Round of 16, the campaign ended in a manner that felt all too familiar. Ronaldo once again made the long walk back to the tunnel in tears. This time, perhaps, there will be no coming back.